ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Extraposition and postponement

Postpone heavy clauses and modifiers while controlling anticipatory subjects, end weight and attachment. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use extraposition and postponement to balance processing load and preserve a clear relationship between postponed material and its grammatical host while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Postpone heavy clauses and modifiers while controlling anticipatory subjects, end weight and attachment.

MODEL

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

anticipatory it/there + predicate + postponed clause

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main extraposition and postponement patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses balance processing load and preserve a clear relationship between postponed material and its grammatical host.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in complex academic, legal and professional prose.

Build meaning before form

Postpone heavy clauses and modifiers while controlling anticipatory subjects, end weight and attachment.

What extraposition and postponement communicates

Postpone heavy clauses and modifiers while controlling anticipatory subjects, end weight and attachment.

The central purpose is to balance processing load and preserve a clear relationship between postponed material and its grammatical host. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.	a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position
We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.	an object proposition postponed after an object complement
A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.	a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: anticipatory it/there + predicate + postponed clause. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “It became clear only later that several files had been altered.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Subject-clause extraposition	it + predicate + that/to-clause	It became clear only later that several files had been altered.
Object extraposition	verb + it + evaluation + clause	We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.
Modifier postponement	head + predicate + long postmodifier	A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position	Subject-clause extraposition
an object proposition postponed after an object complement	Object extraposition
a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance	Modifier postponement

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in complex academic, legal and professional prose. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
anticipatory it/there	predicate	postponed clause

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: balance processing load and preserve a clear relationship between postponed material and its grammatical host.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits complex academic, legal and professional prose.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Subject-clause extraposition	it + predicate + that/to-clause	It became clear only later that several files had been altered.
Object extraposition	verb + it + evaluation + clause	We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.
Modifier postponement	head + predicate + long postmodifier	A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.	a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position
We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.	an object proposition postponed after an object complement
A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.	a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not leave the anticipatory it without a recoverable postponed clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not treat it as a concrete object in this anticipatory pattern.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Use postponed modification only when attachment remains unmistakable.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position?

OPTIONS It became clear only later that several files had been altered. · We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance. · A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an object proposition postponed after an object complement?

OPTIONS We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance. · A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers. · It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance?

OPTIONS A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers. · It became clear only later that several files had been altered. · We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “It became clear only later that several files had been altered.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position · an object proposition postponed after an object complement · a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an object proposition postponed after an object complement · a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance · a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance · a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position · an object proposition postponed after an object complement

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“It became clear only later that several files had been altered.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Subject-clause extraposition / Object extraposition / Modifier postponement · Gap 2: a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position / an object proposition postponed after an object complement / a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Object extraposition / Modifier postponement / Subject-clause extraposition · Gap 2: an object proposition postponed after an object complement / a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance / a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Modifier postponement / Subject-clause extraposition / Object extraposition · Gap 2: a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance / a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position / an object proposition postponed after an object complement

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position: _____. Choose the model that expresses an object proposition postponed after an object complement: _____. Choose the model that expresses a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance: _____. Choose the model built with it + predicate + that/to-clause: _____. Choose the model built with verb + it + evaluation + clause: _____. Choose the model built with head + predicate + long postmodifier: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers. · It became clear only later that several files had been altered. · We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____ only later that several files had been altered. We _____ that the pattern arose by chance. A decision was announced yesterday _____. State the full structural pattern for Subject-clause extraposition: _____. State the full structural pattern for Object extraposition: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “That files had been altered became clear only later.” using the Subject-clause extraposition pattern to express a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “We consider a chance origin unlikely.” using the Object extraposition pattern to express an object proposition postponed after an object complement.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “A decision that surprised advisers was announced yesterday.” using the Modifier postponement pattern to express a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “That files had been altered became clear only later.” using the Subject-clause extraposition pattern to express a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Subject-clause extraposition to express a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Object extraposition to express an object proposition postponed after an object complement, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Modifier postponement to express a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

Subject-clause extraposition is the best match because a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position.

A2

We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

Object extraposition is the best match because an object proposition postponed after an object complement.

A3

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

Modifier postponement is the best match because a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance.

A4

a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position

The Subject-clause extraposition pattern communicates a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position.

A5

an object proposition postponed after an object complement

The Object extraposition pattern communicates an object proposition postponed after an object complement.

A6

a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

The Modifier postponement pattern communicates a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Subject-clause extraposition / a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position

The structure belongs to the Subject-clause extraposition pattern. Its communicative purpose is a heavy subject proposition postponed to end position.

B2

Object extraposition / an object proposition postponed after an object complement

The structure belongs to the Object extraposition pattern. Its communicative purpose is an object proposition postponed after an object complement.

B3

Modifier postponement / a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance

The structure belongs to the Modifier postponement pattern. Its communicative purpose is a heavy modifier postponed to protect clause balance.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

Subject-clause extraposition: it + predicate + that/to-clause.

C2

We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

Object extraposition: verb + it + evaluation + clause.

C3

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

Modifier postponement: head + predicate + long postmodifier.

C4

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

Subject-clause extraposition: it + predicate + that/to-clause.

C5

We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

Object extraposition: verb + it + evaluation + clause.

C6

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

Modifier postponement: head + predicate + long postmodifier.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

It became clear

Subject-clause extraposition requires “It became clear” in this model. it + predicate + that/to-clause.

D2

consider it unlikely

Object extraposition requires “consider it unlikely” in this model. verb + it + evaluation + clause.

D3

that surprised even senior advisers

Modifier postponement requires “that surprised even senior advisers” in this model. head + predicate + long postmodifier.

D4

it + predicate + that/to-clause

Subject-clause extraposition is built as it + predicate + that/to-clause.

D5

verb + it + evaluation + clause

Object extraposition is built as verb + it + evaluation + clause.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

it + predicate + that/to-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended subject-clause extraposition effect.

E2

We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance.

verb + it + evaluation + clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended object extraposition effect.

E3

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers.

head + predicate + long postmodifier. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended modifier postponement effect.

E4

It became clear only later that several files had been altered.

it + predicate + that/to-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended subject-clause extraposition effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

It became clear only later that several files had been altered. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses it + predicate + that/to-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

We consider it unlikely that the pattern arose by chance. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses verb + it + evaluation + clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

A decision was announced yesterday that surprised even senior advisers. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses head + predicate + long postmodifier accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____